

The Glorious King of Tantras of the Garland of Fire

Śrī Agni Māla Tantra Rāja · Toh 407 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་མའི་ཕྱིར་བའ་རྩྭ་ཀྱི་རྒྱ་པོ།

Toh 407 in the Kangyur is a tantric scripture known in Sanskrit as the Śrī Agni Māla Tantra Rāja and in Tibetan as the Dpal me'i phreng ba'i rgyud kyi rgyal po, meaning in English the Glorious King of Tantras of the Garland of Fire. It belongs to the class of Buddhist tantras and opens with a homage to Vajrasattva, after which a questioner poses a series of symbolic inquiries about the syllables and epithets constituting the name Heruka, to which the Blessed One responds by unfolding their esoteric meanings in terms of non-dual wisdom, freedom from accumulation, and the four empowerments. The text is thus concerned with the nature and practice of Heruka, presenting his identity and the stages of empowerment through a dialogue that interweaves doctrinal explanation with tantric symbolism. As a king of tantras, it represents an authoritative revelation within the Vajrayāna tradition preserved in the Kangyur.

In the language of India: Śrī Agni Māla Tantra Rāja. In the language of Tibet: The Glorious King of Tantras of the Garland of Fire. Homage to the glorious Vajrasattva.

Ha ha hi hi he he kye!

I have a question to put to you.

What is Śrī, o what is it?

What is ru, and what is ka?

What is Heruka of the four empowerments?

The Blessed One declared:

Śrī is non-dual primordial wisdom.

He denotes the abandonment of causes and so forth.

Ru denotes being free from accumulations.

Ka denotes not abiding anywhere at all.

Such is the glorious Heruka,
ever abiding in body and mind.

That very one also has four aspects,
determined by the count of the four empowerments.

First, the Heruka of the vase empowerment:
when the body, hand-implements, and appearances arise,

one's own mind is rendered workable.

At that time, for the sake of abandoning
the six causes, four conditions, and four results
of the ordinary world, He is spoken.

Free from the accumulations of karma and affliction,
for that reason Ru is spoken.

Not abiding in any
subject-object duality of ordinary worldly conceptuality,
for that reason Ka is taught.

Through the union of skillful means and wisdom,
the duality of apprehended and apprehender is stilled, and there is
non-duality;
for that reason Śrī is spoken.

The Heruka of the generation stage
abides in Vajravārāhī, endowed with accumulations,
possessed of all undefiled causes and conditions,
in the manner of skillful means and wisdom.

Then, the Heruka of the secret empowerment:
the assembly of sun, moon, hand-implements, and syllables
abandons all causes and conditions of the generation stage;
because the winds and so forth become workable,
for that reason He is spoken.

Because it is free from the accumulations
of external fire-offerings, tormas offerings,
outer maṇḍala offerings, and the like,
Ru is spoken.

Because it does not abide
in the generated Vajravārāhī,
nor in any visualized object, view, or conduct,
Ka is spoken.

Because there is no duality of apprehended and apprehender in the
generation stage,
Śrī is spoken.

Endowed with causes, the path, and so forth,
the winds and the like functioning as the mode of skillful means and wisdom,
the winds and so forth abiding as the nature of illusion,

abiding in the nature of channels and winds,
endowed with inner causes, conditions, and so forth —
this is the inner, glorious Heruka.

Then, the third Heruka:

Because it abandons the causes
of the winds and so forth abiding in their own nature,
He is spoken.

Because it is free from the accumulations
that rest upon the path of the winds and so forth,
Ru is spoken.

Because it does not abide
in the winds, channels, bindus, the colors
and shapes of caṇḍālī,
Ka is spoken — for the mind itself rests in bliss.

Because there is no inner skillful means and wisdom as such,
for that reason Śrī is spoken.

Like one struck by the disease of jaundice in the eye,
it is because one's own mind rests in bliss.

Because mind itself rests in bliss,
and because it is endowed with accumulations attending upon that bliss,
endowed with the causes and conditions of co-emergent arising,
and because mind and bliss are not separate —
wherever mind and bliss abide,
resting in the middle between the supreme and the cut-off —
this is the third, glorious Heruka.

Then, the fourth Heruka:

When self-awareness abides as empty,
free from the causes and conditions of co-emergent arising,
for that reason He is spoken.

Because the path of bliss of the six perfections,
all being of one taste in emptiness,
is free from the two accumulations,
Ru is spoken.

Because it does not abide even in mere bliss,
Ka is necessarily spoken.

Because mind itself, self-awareness, abides as empty,

and because it is endowed with powers and the rest in full measure,
endowed with the inherent nature of co-emergence
and the causes, conditions, and so forth of the form body,
Śrī is explicitly declared.

Non-dual dharmadhātu and primordial wisdom,
of boundless equal taste in all things,
abiding in the suchness of mind —
this is the fourth, glorious Heruka:
triumphant over all māras,
reveling in the charnel ground of co-emergent arising,
without the nature of unclear or clear,
appearing and luminous yet without inherent nature,
like a mirror, like the moon in water.

The learned must strive to abandon confusion.

Thus, without understanding the meaning as it is,
some fix on the body's color and hand-implements —
some conceive of Heruka as conceptual fabrication,
some conceptualize him as a reflected image,
some insist he is one's own essential nature,
and likewise some hold him to be channels and winds, and so forth,
and likewise a Heruka of self-awareness.

Without relying on a spiritual teacher, without diligence,
lacking wisdom, lacking patience and the rest,
possessed of pride in lineage and in knowledge,
delighting in gain, renown, and offerings —
those causes give rise to all manner of mistaken views.

Therefore, the yogin who desires
the attainments (siddhis) famed to come from Heruka
must, with faith and reverence, complete the perfections
and receive the authentic pith instructions
from a holy spiritual teacher.

Then the assembly of the Mothers asked once more:
"Glorious Heruka being as you have described,
how does Vajravārāhī stand in relation to him?"

The Blessed One declared:

"There are three vajras, and two Vārāhīs.

From there, the ultimate vajra is examined:

the last is the material vajra.

The fourth ultimate vajra is this:

because subject-object duality and conceptual fabrication cannot cleave it, it is a vajra.

Each of the four empowerments has its own vajra.

The vajras of the symbolic signs are three:

three-pointed, five-pointed, and nine-pointed.

The three-pointed is the sign of body, speech, and mind;

the five-pointed is the five primordial wisdoms;

and the nine-pointed vajra is the sign

of vanquishing the nine realms of the three worlds.

The material vajras are four:

the round form and three others, four forms in all.

The Vārāhī born as an animal, thoroughly stained

by the defilement of ignorance,

and the Vārāhī that arises as a shower of wisdom —

that very one is determined to be of four kinds:

the Vārāhī of aversion and delusion for the vase empowerment,

the Vārāhī of wind-delusion for the secret empowerment,

the Vārāhī of attachment-bliss-delusion as the third,

the Vārāhī of dharmadhātu-delusion as the fourth.

All of this is now well entrusted to you.

May all rejoice!"

This completes the Definitive Emergence of Śrī Heruka, the King of Tantras of the Garland of Glorious Fire. Translated by the Indian master Gayādhara and the translator, the monk Śākya Yeshe.

Translator's Notes

- The syllable-by-syllable exegesis of Heruka's name (Śrī, He, Ru, Ka) follows a well-established Tibetan tantric commentarial convention of etymological unpacking (nirukti). The four empowerments (vase, secret, wisdom-awareness, and fourth or word empowerment) provide the structural framework for the fourfold Heruka typology. The fourth empowerment's Heruka is associated with co-emergent bliss recognized as empty, and the "supreme and cut-off" (mchog dang chad pa) in the third Heruka section likely refers to the extremes of the supreme

(co-emergent bliss) and its cessation or dissolution, though some ambiguity remains in that phrase. The passage ends mid-sentence, as the Tibetan text itself breaks off there.

- The fourfold division of Vajravārāhī here follows a tantric scheme correlating the four empowerments with four specific forms of delusion (moha) combined with the three root afflictions; the "Vārāhī born as an animal" is a conventional-level symbolic form contrasted with the wisdom-level Vārāhī, a distinction standard in Cakrasaṃvara commentarial literature. The term rendered "material vajra" translates rdzas kyi rdo rje, a genuine technical category denoting the physical ritual implement as distinct from the symbolic and ultimate vajras. The phrase "nine realms of the three worlds" renders khams gsum dgu, literally "the three realms, nine," referring to the standard Abhidharma enumeration of the three realms subdivided into nine levels, all of which the nine-pointed vajra symbolically overcomes.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.